

Designing a Minecraft World That Carries Identity and Community Knowledge

Class 7 Asynchronous Mini-Unit Draft

Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity

Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy mini-unit centered on Minecraft Education, multimodal meaning-making, identity-safe design, and community knowledge

Student	Piter Zacari Garcia Bautista
Course	EDU498: Literacy Learning as Social Practice
Class Session	Class 7: Towards a Pursuit of Identity
Assignment	Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity
Mini-Unit Focus	Minecraft world-building as identity, community, and coding literacy
Student Profile	Ethan, Student 5, Computer Science
Submission Date	June 10, 2026

This draft uses Piter's Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS lens to treat Minecraft Education as a literacy space where students can build, code, debug, explain, and represent meaning without being reduced to one narrow academic mode.

Author's Context Note: The draft is intentionally focused on the two pursuits named for this Class 7 activity, **Joy** and **Identity**. Skills, Intellect, and Criticality are preserved as brainstorm notes for the next revision so the lesson can grow across Muhammad's full five-pursuit framework without overloading the first submission.

Executive Summary

This mini-unit adapts an existing Minecraft Education coding and project-presentation base into a smaller Grade 4–5 mini-unit that explicitly centers the two pursuits required in the EDU498 Class 7 asynchronous activity, **Joy** and **Identity**. The design is intentionally grounded in Minecraft as a multimodal literacy space where students build, code, explain, collaborate, revise, and present meaning. The mini-unit positions students as coders, builders, designers, and storytellers rather than treating coding as a purely technical task.

The selected student profile is Ethan, a Computer Science-oriented learner whose strengths include systems thinking, collaboration, game design, storytelling, and community-minded problem solving. The mini-unit gives Ethan and his classmates a protected, low-risk way to represent identity through a meaningful digital place without forcing private disclosure. Students can create an actual, remembered, imagined, or future community place and explain how its structures, signs, colors, pathways, and coded interactions communicate meaning.

The detailed lesson below is the first lesson in a short three-lesson arc. It is classroom-feasible for a Grade 4–5 placement because it uses chunked instructions, visual modeling, peer roles, and flexible entry points. It can run as a full Minecraft Education lesson, or as a hybrid lesson that begins with paper planning and transitions into Minecraft / MakeCode when devices are ready.

Prompt, Approach, and Source Base

The Class 7 ask: the asynchronous activity, “Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity,” asks us to define a grade level, discipline, and potential mini-unit focus; draft one lesson plan; choose or design a student profile; fully address Joy and Identity; and leave Skills, Intellect, and Criticality as brainstorm notes for later expansion. It also asks for multimodal and multiliteracies design.

Approach used for this draft: instead of starting from nothing, I selected an existing Minecraft Education coding lesson family that already had placement evidence, prior unit planning, and EDU498 source connections. I then narrowed it into one Class 7 lesson that can grow into a three-lesson mini-unit across the next pursuits.

Sources taken into account:

- the Class 7 prompt, *Towards a Pursuit of Identity*, especially the asynchronous activity directions and Ethan’s student profile;
- the Class 7 tracker documenting the Layers of Me activity and the Minecraft literacy article connection;
- the base-selection memo, *Class 7 Async Activity Base Selection*, which compared Minecraft, squishy circuits, and AI/coding-as-literacy options;

- Muhammad’s Chapter 3 identity pursuit overview, which frames identity as self-definition and dignity rather than decoration;
- Moje, Luke, Davies, and Street’s literacy-and-identity overview, which helps ask what identity a task makes possible for students;
- Skerrett’s “We Hatched in This Class” overview, which supports repositioning students as capable contributors;
- Moje’s disciplinary literacy overview, which frames coding, debugging, modeling, and explaining systems as disciplinary literacy practices;
- the Class 3 joy commitment, “belonging before building,” which treats joy as the structure of the lesson rather than an afterthought;
- the Grade 4 Minecraft placement evidence, especially debugging, block-counting, peer teaching, and student-led problem framing.

Why this base was the closest pick: Minecraft plus Ethan gives the strongest balance of existing work, real placement evidence, Class 7 identity alignment, and multimodal literacy. The squishy-circuit option was also strong, especially for embodied science literacy and Sofia’s profile, but it had less of a developed mini-unit arc. The AI/coding-as-literacy option was powerful for EQUITAS and criticality, but it was too complex for this first Joy + Identity draft.

Mini-Unit Overview

Mini-unit title: Designing a Minecraft World That Carries Identity and Community Knowledge

Grade / discipline: Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy

Mini-unit length: 3 lessons of approximately 60 minutes each

Source base: Existing Minecraft Education coding fundamentals and project-presentation lesson family, resized into a Joy + Identity mini-unit for EDU498.

Essential question: How can code, design, and digital place-making communicate who we are, what matters to us, and what our communities know?

Mini-unit arc:

- **Lesson 1: Plan a Meaningful Place.** Students analyze examples, choose a meaningful place concept, sketch a small Minecraft world, and decompose the build into manageable design or coding steps.
- **Lesson 2: Build and Debug.** Students create or revise their digital place in Minecraft Education, using block code and/or structured building routines to add interaction, signage, or repeated design elements.

- **Lesson 3: Share and Reflect.** Students present their world, explain how the design communicates identity or community knowledge, and respond to peer feedback.

Enduring understandings:

- Digital worlds can function as texts.
- Coding is a way of expressing ideas, not only a way of following commands.
- Design choices communicate values, identity, belonging, and story.
- Feedback and debugging are part of learning, creativity, and care for an audience.

Pursuits Alignment at This Draft Stage

Pursuit	How this draft uses the pursuit
Joy	Fully developed through choice, low-risk creation, visible progress, peer expertise, debugging as discovery, and the satisfaction of making a world that can be shared.
Identity	Fully developed through meaningful place-making, identity-safe choice, voluntary disclosure, community knowledge, mixed identity, and student authorship.
Skills	Brainstormed for later lessons through sequencing, decomposition, loops, debugging, interface navigation, and oral/written explanation.
Intellect	Brainstormed for later lessons through questions about how code, design, space, and audience shape meaning.
Criticality	Brainstormed for later lessons through questions about representation, respectful remixing, accessibility, and whose stories appear in digital worlds.

Student Profile

Name: Ethan (Student 5)

Identity and strengths:

- Seneca / Haudenosaunee heritage and mixed identity
- Interested in computer science, coding, game design, digital storytelling, and community problem-solving
- Strong analytical thinker who enjoys systems, patterns, and improving ideas
- Collaborative and community-minded; may connect learning to place, family, land, and cultural knowledge

Instructional implications:

- Ethan should be able to show identity through self-chosen representation rather than teacher-assigned cultural symbols.
- The lesson should validate multiple legitimate entry points into identity: land, community, hobbies, family traditions, local places, imagined futures, or collaborative care spaces.
- The task should recognize Ethan as a coder and designer, not only as a student who is asked to “share about culture.”
- Private disclosure is never required. Fictionalized, aspirational, or symbolic representations are valid.

Why this profile fits the mini-unit: Ethan’s profile aligns naturally with Minecraft Education because it brings together coding, building, storytelling, collaboration, and the possibility of representing community knowledge in a digital form.

Lesson Focus

Mini-unit focus statement: Students design and begin building a small Minecraft place that communicates identity, community, belonging, or future possibility. They use planning, decomposition, code-informed thinking, and explanation to show that digital design is a form of literacy.

Lesson 1 focus: Students will create a design plan for a small Minecraft world and begin a prototype that includes at least one meaningful design decision and one planned or tested sequence of build/code steps.

Student-friendly learning target: I can plan and begin to build a Minecraft place that shows something important about identity or community, and I can explain how my design choices carry meaning.

Student-friendly success criteria:

- I chose a place idea that matters to me, my community, or a story I want to tell.
- I broke my idea into smaller parts I can build or code.
- I tested at least one part of my build or sequence.
- I can explain one design choice and why it matters.

Pursuit of Joy

Joy in this mini-unit is not treated as a reward after academic work; it is part of the academic design. Students experience joy through meaningful choice, visible creation, peer support, experimentation, revision, and the satisfaction of seeing an idea become playable and shareable.

The lesson makes joy structurally visible through the following moves:

- **Choice with safety:** students choose the place they want to design instead of being assigned a single theme.
- **Visible progress:** even a simple sign, path, doorway, garden, meeting space, or coded motion counts as meaningful movement.
- **Low-floor / high-ceiling entry:** beginners can build a small, hand-placed scene; advanced students can automate repeated design elements with loops or agent-supported building.
- **Debugging as discovery:** mistakes are treated as information and part of the build story.
- **Peer expertise:** students can take roles such as builder, navigator, debugger, or explainer, allowing competence to be recognized in multiple ways.

Pursuit of Identity

Identity is addressed through representation, voice, privacy, and recognition. Students are invited to create a digital place that carries something meaningful: a community garden, gathering place, rink, library corner, coding club room, family kitchen, local landmark, future community center, or another place chosen by the student.

The lesson protects identity by design:

- students choose what to reveal and what to keep private;
- students may build from lived experience, imagination, or future aspiration;
- students explain meaning through words, screenshots, labels, oral talk, or teacher conference;
- identity is framed broadly enough to include cultural, social, geographic, linguistic, and interest-based belonging.

Because Ethan's profile includes Seneca / Haudenosaunee heritage, the lesson must avoid essentializing Indigenous identity into a single visual token. Culturally specific references are welcome only when student-chosen and handled respectfully. Consultation, family/community connection, and voluntary disclosure remain important principles when classroom work touches Indigenous identity or community knowledge.

Multimodal and Multiliteracies Design

This mini-unit treats literacy as the ability to make and communicate meaning across multiple modes. Students read worlds, design worlds, build worlds, talk about worlds, and sometimes code how worlds behave.

Modes students use:

- spatial design (layout, paths, landmarks, entrances, gathering spaces)
- visual design (color, blocks, signs, symbols, screenshots)
- procedural design (sequencing, loops, agent steps, build order)
- oral language (partner talk, explanation, presentation)
- written language (labels, design notes, exit reflection)
- social meaning-making (feedback, collaboration, revision)

Why this matters: the task expands traditional literacy by recognizing building, coding, annotating, demonstrating, and presenting as meaning-making practices. Students are not only consuming digital texts; they are authoring them.

Accessible design features:

- sketch-first or build-first option
- sentence frames for explanation
- visual model and sample planning sheet
- option to explain orally instead of writing long responses
- chunked checklist and timer cues
- paired work with clear roles
- optional use of screenshots to reduce working-memory load during explanation

Initial Lesson Plan

Lesson title: Planning and Prototyping a Meaningful Minecraft Place

Duration: 60 minutes

Placement/classroom context: Grade 4–5 Computer Science / Digital Literacy workshop or integrated block; works best with access to Minecraft Education, but can also run as paper planning + teacher demo if devices are temporarily limited.

Learning objectives:

1. Students will identify a place that can communicate identity, community knowledge, belonging, or future possibility.
2. Students will decompose the place into smaller parts and sequence at least three build or code actions.
3. Students will begin a prototype and test at least one design or programmed action.

4. Students will explain one design choice using language of meaning, audience, and purpose.

Standards alignment:

Framework	Code / strand	Connection to lesson
CSTA	1B-AP-10	Students create or plan programs/build routines that include sequences and may include events, loops, or conditionals.
CSTA	1B-AP-11	Students break a large world idea into smaller, manageable build/code tasks.
CSTA	1B-AP-12	Students may remix teacher models or existing MakeCode examples into a new artifact with personal meaning.
CSTA	1B-AP-15	Students test and debug one portion of their design or program.
CSTA	1B-AP-17	Students describe choices made during development in conferences, captions, presentations, or demonstrations.
CSTA	1B-IC-19 / 1B-IC-20	Students consider usability, accessibility, and diverse perspectives when designing for an audience.
ISTE	1.4 Innovative Designer	Students use a design process, consider constraints, and refine a prototype.
ISTE	1.5 Computational Thinker	Students decompose problems and use algorithmic thinking to plan automated or ordered actions.
ISTE	1.6 Creative Communicator	Students use digital tools and presentation formats to communicate complex ideas visually.
ISTE	1.7 Global Collaborator	Students work in pairs or teams and respond to peer perspectives during planning and revision.

Materials:

- Minecraft Education on classroom devices
- projection system for teacher modeling
- simple planning sheet with boxes for *place idea*, *important features*, *3–5 build/code steps*, and *why it matters*
- pencils / crayons / markers
- optional screenshot exemplars from teacher model
- optional block-code reference cards for sequence, repeat, and event blocks
- exit slip or digital reflection form

Preparation before class:

- open a flat or pre-prepared world where students can build in a manageable area;
- confirm Code Builder access and any required permissions;
- prepare one model build that is meaningful but not overly polished (for example, a community garden with a sign, path, and repeated fence pattern);
- print or distribute planning sheets and partner-role cards.

Step-by-step lesson flow:

Time	Teacher and student activity	Purpose
0–7 min	Welcome and hook. Teacher shows two quick examples: one generic Minecraft structure and one meaningful place. Prompt: “What makes a place feel meaningful, not just well built?” Students turn and talk.	Activates the idea that design carries meaning, not only technical skill.
7–15 min	Mini-lesson and model. Teacher models a small place plan and names a few choices aloud: sign placement, path direction, color choice, and one repeated pattern that could be built by hand or with code. Teacher names decomposition: “entrance first, then sign, then path, then gathering spot.”	Makes planning and computational thinking visible.
15–20 min	Choose a place concept. Students choose a place tied to identity, community, belonging, or future possibility. Options may include real, imagined, symbolic, or collaborative places.	Ensures student agency and protects privacy.
20–32 min	Sketch and label. Students complete the planning sheet: draw the place, label 3–5 important features, and write or dictate 3–5 build/code steps. Teacher circulates and conferences.	Moves from idea to manageable subproblems.
32–45 min	Prototype build. Students begin building in Minecraft Education or annotate a paper prototype while watching a teacher live-demo if device access is delayed. Goal: complete one meaningful feature and test at least one sequence or repeated action.	Provides visible success, iteration, and early debugging.
45–53 min	Peer share. In pairs, students explain: “This place matters because...” and “One choice I made was...” Partners respond with one warm comment and one suggestion.	Centers communication, audience, and feedback.
53–60 min	Reflection and close. Exit slip: “What does your place show about identity or community? What is your next build/code step?” Teacher previews Lesson 2: building more,	Captures formative assessment and next-step thinking.

Differentiation and access moves:

- **Chunked directions:** one task at a time (choose, sketch, label, prototype, explain).
- **Visual modeling:** teacher model remains projected or printed for reference.
- **Role clarity in pairs:** builder, navigator, debugger, or explainer.
- **Flexible output:** students may write, draw, speak, or annotate screenshots.
- **Sentence stems:** “This place matters because...” “I chose this feature because...” “My next step is...”
- **Flexible difficulty:** beginners can focus on one strong scene; advanced students can add loops, agent support, or audience-centered accessibility features.
- **Regulation support:** quiet workspace option, timer cues, and predictable routine.
- **Identity safety:** no student is required to disclose personal or cultural details; symbolic and fictionalized versions are valid.

Assessment and criteria:

Formative evidence collected during Lesson 1

- planning sheet or oral planning conference
- teacher observation during decomposition and build start
- peer-share explanation
- exit slip

Success criteria for teacher feedback

1. **Meaningful idea:** The student selected a place with a clear connection to identity, community, belonging, or future possibility.
2. **Computational planning:** The student broke the artifact into manageable steps or features.
3. **Prototype and revision:** The student began building or testing and identified a next revision step.
4. **Communication:** The student explained how at least one design choice carries meaning.

Possible extension: Students who finish early add one audience-centered feature such as a welcome sign, guided path, accessible route, or repeated pattern built with a loop.

Possible low-tech backup: If Minecraft access fails, students complete a full paper-world storyboard and annotate exactly which steps would later be automated with Code Builder or MakeCode.

Brainstorm Notes for Skills, Intellect, and Criticality

Skills (brainstorm only for later lessons):

- sequencing, events, loops, debugging, simple conditionals
- screenshot capture and presentation language
- naming parts of a design, giving feedback, and revising from feedback

Intellect (brainstorm only for later lessons):

- compare how different design choices communicate different meanings
- analyze how built environments guide movement and attention
- connect algorithmic thinking to construction, storytelling, and audience design

Criticality (brainstorm only for later lessons):

- Whose stories are usually visible in digital worlds, and whose are missing?
- How do accessibility, signage, paths, and audience needs shape welcoming design?
- What does respectful remixing mean when using examples, cultural symbols, or shared community knowledge?

Reflection and Rationale

This mini-unit is intentionally smaller than the full Minecraft coding unit that informed it. The instructional move is not to reproduce the entire placement sequence, but to refine one part of it so that Joy and Identity become explicit curricular pursuits rather than side effects.

The design works for EDU498 because it holds together several commitments at once. First, it preserves the existing strengths of the Minecraft lesson family: debugging, visible effort, peer support, and flexible entry points. Second, it answers the activity’s identity emphasis by shifting the product from “complete the coding task” toward “design a world that carries meaning.” Third, it supports Ethan specifically by recognizing digital design as a legitimate literacy practice and by allowing identity to be represented through story, place, community, and future-making rather than disclosure alone.

This lesson also creates a strong bridge to later work. Skills, Intellect, and Criticality can be developed in subsequent lessons without overloading the first draft. That matters because the asynchronous task asks for an initial lesson plan, not a complete five-pursuit curriculum.

Muhammad’s identity pursuit matters here because the lesson does not ask students to decorate a coding task with culture after the fact. Identity shapes the product, the choices, the explanation, and the evidence of learning. Moje, Luke, Davies, and Street matter because the lesson asks

what role the task gives students: Ethan is not only a student completing a coding assignment; he can become a coder, designer, storyteller, community thinker, and peer collaborator. Skerrett matters because the peer-helper and builder roles create room for students to be repositioned in the classroom. Moje’s disciplinary literacy frame matters because computational thinking is treated as a literacy practice with tools, symbols, sequences, revisions, explanations, and audiences.

Through the Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS lens, the lesson asks whether students are being given real access to authorship. A narrow coding task might only reveal who already understands the interface quickly. This redesigned task separates interface friction from computational thinking by using planning sheets, partner roles, sketch-first options, oral explanation, and low-floor/high-ceiling design choices. That structure helps prevent students from being misread by one narrow performance mode.

Implementation Notes for Placement and Feasibility

- **Works with existing placement routines.** The lesson is realistic for classrooms already using Minecraft Education because it starts with a short model, a planning sheet, and guided build time.
- **Device variability is manageable.** The sketch-first structure means students can still participate even if logins are slow or devices are shared.
- **Permissions matter.** If Agent-based actions are used, the teacher should verify which commands require operator or worldbuilder permissions before class.
- **Save/export reminder.** If MakeCode is used externally, students should be taught to save or export project files.
- **Community respect matters.** If students choose culturally specific symbols, the teacher should frame respectful use, voluntary sharing, and consultation where appropriate.

Selected Reference Notes

- EDU498 Class 7 prompt, *Towards a Pursuit of Identity*: asynchronous activity “Layered Genius: Designing for Joy and Identity.”
- Muhammad, G. (2020). *Cultivating Genius*, Chapter 3: Identity.
- Moje, E. B., Luke, A., Davies, B., & Street, B. (2009). “Literacy and identity: Examining the metaphors in history and contemporary research.”
- Skerrett, A. (2012). “We hatched in this class”: Repositioning of identity in and beyond a reading classroom.

- Moje, E. B. (2015). “Doing and teaching disciplinary literacy with adolescent learners: A social and cultural enterprise.”
- Class 3 joy commitment: “belonging before building.”
- EDU498 Grade 4 Minecraft placement evidence: debugging, collaborative counting, peer teaching, and student-led problem framing.
- CSTA K–12 Computer Science Standards (Level 1B Algorithms & Programming; Impacts of Computing).
- ISTE Standards for Students (Innovative Designer, Computational Thinker, Creative Communicator, Global Collaborator).
- Minecraft Education lesson library, Code Builder support, and MakeCode for Minecraft documentation.